

A Mailman for Your Business

Small businesses face a perennial dilemma—to outsource e-mail services, or create an in-house system. Here are a few reasons why outsourcing could help

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E-mail is an indispensable part of business today, be it a start-up or a Small or Medium Enterprise (SME). With GBs of e-mail space available for free, it is tempting to just use any such free services for the business needs of the SME. However, just any e-mail ID cannot be used for official correspondence. It is far savvier to have an e-mail ID that contains your company name, and also yours! The statement it makes at once impresses clients as being authentic.

But owning a domain name and running a mail server is expensive, especially if it has to be

used for commercial purposes. It needs to be secure, well-maintained, and capable of handling and storing large amounts of data. "If e-mail is critical to a business, it makes sense to have separate providers for Web hosting and e-mail," says Abbas S Dean, IT manager, Mumbai Liaison office, Anglo Eastern Ship Management. This Mumbai-based organisation has around 60 users in its office. Though they do not have a resident mail administrator in their Mumbai office, they would prefer to have their mail-server in-house. "It would give us more flexibility," he says. They use MS Exchange on an XP/2000 platform.

This solution makes eminent sense if you are a large corporation. But if you are a start-up, or an enterprise not directly involved in IT, these technical details can be daunting. It is possible to learn all this, or else, look for options elsewhere.

Attention! Mailman Wanted

There are various solutions available for the Small and Medium Enterprise (SME) sector. Hardware is cheap, and software prices vary according to the kind of license needed since the needs of a typical SME are not too high.

There are problems though. A mail server needs to continuously connected to the Internet, otherwise mails will bounce, and typically, cannot be retrieved unless there is a perimeter server in place.

There are also risks of virus infections, malicious attacks and the Denial of Service (DoS) attacks. Some viruses on the prowl can send hundreds of thousands of e-mails from e-mail accounts, eating up bandwidth and forcing clients to block mails from the server. This means enterprise grade firewalls and antivirus software, which in turn means constant monitoring of the mail server, and high costs.

Technology needs pampering to run, and much to the chagrin of us all, pampering costs money.

Still, businesses tend to host mail servers in-house. The security, as well as the freedom of managing a server in-house has a higher comfort level for most businesses.

Trust and security are most important, says Kuldeep Sharma of Cravitex Ltd Mumbai, a firm that markets and exports apparel, footwear and fitness systems. Cravitex hosts their mail server in-house, running MDAemon (a product by C&C software) on the local LAN on NT.

It has outsourced the external mail server to a hosting service. However, bandwidth and



Illustration: Mahesh Benkar